



Raising VUCA- Ready children for a Changing world

We live in a world that is constantly changing—sometimes in ways we cannot predict or control. For children, this can be both overwhelming and exciting. The term VUCA—Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity—originally described the unpredictable nature of global business and leadership. Today, it is no longer confined to boardrooms. It has become the lived reality of classrooms, homes, and playgrounds.



■ Dr. Manjula Pooja Shroff
Founder Chairperson, MD & CEO
Kalorex group

Living Through VUCA Moments

Take nine-year-old Aarav. His cricket practice was abruptly cancelled due to sudden rains. Disappointed but undeterred, he turned his attention to an online art competition. Later that day, his internet failed in the middle of a science quiz. Confused at first, he calmed down only when his teacher reassured him he could reattempt it.

In a single day, Aarav navigated volatility, adapted to uncertainty, and learned to reset expectations—hallmarks of VUCA readiness. Neuroscience shows that such situations strengthen children's executive functions—self-control, working memory, and flexible thinking (Harvard Centre on the Developing Child, 2021).

Fourteen-year-old Meera, however, struggled differently. When her school introduced open-book testing for board exams, she panicked. Instead of adapting, she retreated into endless scrolling on social media. Her grades dipped, not because of the change itself, but because she lacked resilience.

UNICEF warns that children who do not build emotional adaptability are more likely to face long-term well-being challenges than academic ones (2022).

Together, Aarav and Meera highlight a crucial truth: adaptability, not intelligence, is the differentiator in uncertain times.

The Global Irony

This truth resonates even more when viewed against today's global context. Across many countries, Indians—who studied in Indian classrooms but went abroad to build careers—are now facing resentment from host-country citizens. The irony is stark: the very skills, resilience, and intellect nurtured in India are powering economies worldwide, yet our citizens often find themselves negotiating identity, belonging, and acceptance abroad.

This paradox highlights an urgent need. Beyond equipping children with academic brilliance, we must prepare them for the emotional turbulence, cross-cultural complexity, and adaptive resilience required to thrive in a volatile global landscape.

Preparing Children for the Future

The World Economic Forum estimates that 65% of today's schoolchildren will work in jobs that don't yet exist (2023). Preparing them only for exams is like handing them a map for a territory that has already changed. What they need are future-proof skills:

- the ability to think critically, not just recall information,
- the confidence to regulate emotions in chaos, and
- the capacity to collaborate across differences.

These are no longer “add-ons” to education—they are survival skills. And through its VUCA curriculum and published resources, Kalorex is making this preparation systematic, measurable, and future-

focused.

Dr. Manjula Pooja Shroff's Vision

Dr. Manjula Pooja Shroff-Founder Chairperson, MD & CEO of Kalorex group has long championed the idea that education must move beyond rote learning to future readiness. A pioneer in education and parenting innovation, she believes shielding children from disruption is a disservice. Instead, the true responsibility of parents and educators is to guide children through uncertainty with resilience, empathy, and adaptability.

Her vision is clear: whether children remain in India or venture abroad, they must be equipped to face environments that test not just technical brilliance but also emotional intelligence, cultural agility, and courage under pressure.

By encouraging exploration, normalizing failure, and creating safe spaces for children to take risks without fear of judgment, Dr. Shroff emphasizes that we prepare not just successful students, but strong global citizens. What makes her vision distinctive is not just policy but practice. As part of her mission, Dr Shroff has been travelling across the length and breadth of the country, engaging with educators, parents and communities. She speaks, and inspires with a singular purpose-to prepare India's children to be adaptive, resilient and humane leaders in a VUCA world.

To conclude, in a world that is volatile, uncertain, complex, and ambiguous, children will need to evolve constantly. The ability to stay grounded while adapting to change will be their greatest strength—whether in their homeland or on the global stage.

As Dr. Shroff reminds us:

“Let us not raise children for the world we grew up in, but for the world they are growing into.”